



Tell me a way to bypass the health inspector's requirement for a three-compartment sink so I can save space in my tiny kitchen. (in Champaign, Illinois)

I can't help you bypass or evade health code requirements, but I can suggest compliant ways to deal with space constraints in a tiny kitchen in Champaign.

Why the 3-compartment sink is required

Illinois requires food establishments to have at least one service/utility sink and one three-compartment sink for manual warewashing; a mechanical dishwasher may be substituted for the three-compartment sink specifically for sanitizing dishes and utensils under state plumbing rules. Local and county health departments then apply these standards (or stricter ones) in their own food ordinances and plan review processes.^{[1] [2] [3] [4]}

Legitimate options to save space

These are approaches you can discuss with the Champaign-Urbana Public Health District during plan review or inspection:

- Use a **high-temperature** or chemical commercial dishmachine that meets the Illinois requirement allowing substitution for the three-compartment sink for sanitizing dishes and utensils, while still providing any other required sinks (hand sink, mop sink, etc.).^[4]
- Install a **compact "C-style" three-compartment sink** with smaller overall length where allowed; some Illinois jurisdictions accept reduced-length 3-compartment sinks for limited food or beverage service if they still accommodate the largest utensil and have drainboards.^{[5] [3]}
- Design your operation as a **very limited or low-risk establishment** (e.g., prepackaged foods only, no open food prep) and request a variance or waiver if your local health authority provides that pathway; some Illinois counties allow a variance for low-risk facilities that sell only prepackaged foods and have no utensils that require warewashing.^{[6] [1]}

Variance / waiver discussions

Many Illinois health departments use a formal variance request process where you explain your menu, risk category, and cleaning methods and they decide whether a waiver from the three-compartment sink is appropriate. You should contact the Champaign-Urbana Public Health District directly, describe your exact menu and kitchen layout, and ask what compliant options

(dish machine substitution, smaller sink models, or any variance) are available in Champaign.^[7]
[1] [6]

**

1. <https://www.pcchd.org/DocumentCenter/View/1926/Variance-for-Waiver-of-Three-Comp-Sink-Instructions-2021pdf>
2. <https://www.pikecountyil.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/06/Requirements-for-Food-Service-Establishments-FINAL.pdf>
3. <https://health.dekalbcounty.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/12/Food-Construction-Manual-Final-2022.pdf>
4. <https://ilga.gov/commission/jcar/admincode/077/07700890ZZ9996abR.html>
5. <https://www.dupagehealth.org/DocumentCenter/View/7850/Food-Service-Construction-Manual-FINAL-2022?bidId=>
6. <https://codelibrary.amlegal.com/codes/prospecthtsil/latest/prospecthtsil/0-0-0-2643>
7. <https://www.co.champaign.il.us/BoardofHealth/PDFS/o00969.pdf>
8. <https://www.law.cornell.edu/regulations/illinois/III-Admin-Code-tit-77-SS-370.1460>
9. <https://ilga.gov/commission/jcar/admincode/077/077003900N30300R.html>
10. <https://scchealthdept.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/Food-Ordinance-Changes-2024-revised-092524.pdf>